

different modes would hardly matter. All that they would look for is a simple, soothing listening experience. Marshall Acton III delivers on that.

The app has some controls, which you essentially get on the speaker itself. So, no brownie points there. However, one feature that I found interesting was - Placement Compensation. This is something that we usually see in soundbars, where the device compensates for the anomalies in its surroundings and adjusts its sound to give you the optimal listening experience. At the Test Centre, I was able to put this to test, and the speaker did fairly well to make up for all the boxes and other stuff I had dumped around it. The only catch here is that the speaker does not make the changes on its own. It is you, filling out a questionnaire, and the speaker adjusts accordingly. I would say go ahead and experiment with the feature, but if you are not one for fiddling around a lot, then adjust the bass and treble on your own.

PERFORMANCE

What the Marshall Acton III loses out in terms of features, it makes up in its performance. The sound coming out of this speaker is one of the most complete sounds you will hear in the consumer-grade speakers market. The sound signature of the Marshall Acton III is V-shaped, meaning that there is a noticeable boost in the lows and the highs (bass and treble). However, as my fellow reviewer Dhriti had noted in her review of the Marshall Woburn III, the tuning of the drivers by Marshall is so on point that the boost does not eat into the mids at all.

I am a fan of the band OneRepublic, and we happen to use their song, Rescue Me in our test process to test out the vocal clarity of speakers. And, when I played that song, I was impressed. I played around with the bass and treble settings to try and drown out the vocals. However, even at maxed-out bass, which is something that is very extreme and I am sure no one would do that, the speaker managed to produce the vocals



with astonishing precision. Not only that, tracks like Selkies, Pull Me Under, and Skyfall, which are used by us in our testing, were reproduced well by the Acton III. And, when you listen to the speaker play every single one of these songs in the way they are intended to, you understand why Marshall is held in such high regard and why they charge so much for their speakers. The most optimal settings for the speaker, at least for the people here at the Test Centre, was setting the bass and the treble knobs to the middle, occasionally cranking up the bass a bit, max up to 70 per cent if we were in the mood for it.

However, there were a couple of gripes I had with the speaker. When cranking the volume to max, to make up for some of the distortion which would creep in, the Digital Signal Processing engine was getting triggered, which meant that the speaker's sound signature wasn't what you would find at, say 60 per cent volume. So, I would recommend, for optimal listening experience, do not go over the 80 per cent mark.

The second was that a speaker over ₹30,000, comes with only SBC CODEC! I don't know what is the reasoning behind not having a higher quality CODEC in the speaker, but the lack of aptX or LDAC is something you cannot look past. If you want to unlock the full potential of the speaker, you have to use the 3.5mm AUX port, which is a shame.

Lastly, in terms of its gaming performance, yes, I played games, while having the speaker connected to our

Test Centre's PS5. The speaker holds its own. I had it connected through a 3.5mm cable from my DualSense controller, and in games like F1 23 and Mortal Kombat 1, the speaker did well in terms of reproduction of positionally sound audio and every kick and thump that was there in the game.

And, yeah, you will see that this review is missing the battery performance section. That is because the speaker is powered off the wall and comes with no battery baked in. I have seen offerings in similar form factor come with batteries included. The only reason I can see why Marshall opted out of adding batteries is because the drivers included in the speaker, to provide the sound that the brand was gunning for, needed a lot of power, which would have drained any battery included in the speaker in a jiffy.

VERDICT

The Marshall Acton III makes for a great luxury listening experience. You get whatever you could dream of in a speaker when it comes to build and design, and casual listening performance. The lack of a battery, some missing CODECs, and features are something that could be a deal breaker for you, pushing you towards economical options like the AIWA RSX-150 Natsukasii Pro. However, if you are looking for a premium listening experience on a speaker that with proper care will last you a lifetime, and also makes for a great addition to the decor of your living room, then you cannot look past the Marshall Acton III.

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

FREQUENCY RANGE: 45-20,000 Hz | MAXIMUM SOUND PRESSURE LEVEL: 95 dB @ 1 m | CABINET PRINCIPLE: Bass-reflex | POWER AMPLIFIERS: One 30 Watt Class D amplifier for the woofer, Two 15 Watt Class D amplifiers for the tweeters | WIRELESS CONNECTIVITY: Bluetooth 5.2, Ready for Bluetooth LE Audio | DIMENSIONS: 260 x 170 x 150 mm | WEIGHT: 2.85 kg

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